

Executive Summary

Organizations understand they must build new skills to remain competitive. The question is no longer whether upskilling matters, but whether organizations are equipped to deliver it effectively.

“HR.com’s Future of Learning Technology and Upskilling 2026” survey reveals a growing gap between ambition and execution. Two-thirds of organizations expect employee upskilling to become more or much more important over the next two years, yet only 30% rate their learning and development (L&D) efforts as highly effective.

Skills gaps continue to affect every level of the workforce, with mid-level managers emerging as the group most in need of development. At the same time, learning remains disconnected from broader talent strategies and daily work for many organizations. Only 17% report full alignment between learning and talent management, while just 37% say their primary learning platform is fully integrated with their HR system.

Artificial intelligence is adding new urgency to this challenge. Organizations are rapidly adopting AI to improve access to knowledge, automate learning tasks, and personalize development. However, only one-quarter of organizations are developing an AI reskilling strategy, and relatively few have established a mature approach to preparing employees for an AI-enabled workplace.

The findings suggest that organizations will need to build learning ecosystems that align with business priorities, integrate learning into everyday work, use technology more strategically, and give employees a continuous path to develop new skills.

About this Research

“HR.com’s Future of Learning Technology and Upskilling 2026” report combines insights from three research sources:

- The primary research source is “HR.com’s Future of Learning Technology and Upskilling 2026” survey, which ran from April 2026 to June 2026. We gathered responses from 94 HR professionals across virtually every industry vertical. Respondents are located around the world, although most reside in North America, particularly the United States.
- To provide additional context on adoption of learning technology the report also includes findings from the HR Research Institute (HRRI) pulse survey conducted among 141 HR.com webcast registrants in June 2026.
- Finally, the report incorporates qualitative insights from HR leaders with expertise in learning technology and upskilling.

Our Major Research Findings

Major Finding 1

Organizations recognize that upskilling is a strategic priority, but most have yet to build highly effective learning functions.

- Only 30% rate their L&D efforts as highly effective.
- Two-thirds expect employee upskilling to become more or much more important over the next two years.
- Only 17% report that learning is fully aligned with talent acquisition, succession planning, and performance management.
- Nearly one-third (32%) say upskilling is not a priority for top leadership, highlighting a disconnect between business needs and executive commitment.

Major Finding 2

Skills gaps remain widespread, yet learning continues to be reactive rather than continuous.

- 56% report frequent skills gaps among mid-level managers, the highest of any employee group.
- 58% say employees upskill only when an immediate need arises.
- Only 18% report that employees engage in continuous learning.
- Just 37% say employees are given dedicated time to learn during the workday.

Major Finding 3

Learning technology is widely adopted, but fragmented systems limit its strategic value.

- 67% use a Learning Management System (LMS) or Learning Experience Platform (LXP).
- AI-powered learning tools are one of the fastest-growing learning technologies with 37% currently adopting them versus 15% last year.
- Only 37% report their primary LMS is fully integrated with their HR system and just 44% say learning systems integrate well with HR and other enterprise platforms.
- The biggest technology weaknesses are lack of integration into the flow of work (39%), lack of personalization (37%), and poor integration with other systems (32%).

Major Finding 4

Learning technologies perform well for administration and compliance but fall short in building workforce capability.

- 88% rate their learning technologies as effective for compliance and regulatory training.
- Only 13% say their learning technologies are extremely effective at closing skill gaps and just 14% say the same about delivering personalized learning experiences.
- Nearly two-thirds (65%) measure learning success through immediate knowledge or skill improvement, while only 28% formally calculate learning return on investment (ROI).
- Just 11% say learning is fully embedded into employees' daily workflows.

Major Finding 5

AI is transforming workplace learning, but organizational readiness remains in the early stages.

- 72% use AI to help employees search and access organizational knowledge.
- 56% use AI for administrative automation or content generation, while 52% provide personalized learning recommendations.
- 26% report their AI reskilling strategy is still under development.
- Only 17% have a formal AI reskilling strategy in place and 19% still have no strategy.
- 74% develop AI skills through supported hands-on experimentation, yet only 17% are actively researching or evaluating agentic AI for L&D.